an extent that it impacted its own relationship with the West. What is important to note is that this criticism, whether on bilateral or global issues, is not a retrospective one but offered even as events were then unfolding.

After the 1962 border conflict, India and China exchanged ambassadors only in 1976, a decision taken by the Indira Gandhi government. It then took till 1988 for the first Indian prime ministerial visit to China after 1954, that of Rajiv Gandhi. And indeed, the re-building of our ties was actually a very painstaking endeavour. This, if you think about it, is something of a paradox. Because, do remember that India was among the early nations to actually recognize the People's Republic of China (PRC). However, the quality of our ties in many ways was determined by the border conflict and the three distant decades thereafter.

It took a conscious effort on the part of both nations to orchestrate a recovery and restore a sense of normalcy. As a result, for the next many years, interactions and exchanges grew steadily in many areas. China became one of our largest trading partners; a very significant source of investment, even of technology; a participant in projects and infrastructure building; and a substantial destination for tourism and education. As for the border areas, a detailed and practical set of understandings and agreements focussed on their management, even as negotiations were conducted on the resolution of the boundary dispute.

The advancement of India–China ties since 1988 was obviously predicated on ensuring that peace and tranquillity in the border areas would be maintained and that the Line of Actual Control (LAC) observed and respected by both sides. For this reason, it was agreed in 1993 that no activities of either side shall overstep the LAC; that the two sides shall keep military forces along the LAC to a level compatible with good relations; and that prior notification for military exercises near the LAC would be given.

In 1996, these commitments were not only reaffirmed but further developed through additional provisions. It was decided that the two sides would reduce or limit the number of army, border defence and paramilitary forces along the LAC and exchange data accordingly. More importantly, it was explicitly recognized that large-scale military exercises involving more than one division (15,000 troops) would not be held in close proximity to the LAC. If that were to be conducted, the strategic direction of the main force involved shall not be towards the other side. The 1996 agreement also